The Journal of Open Source Software

Scikit-Longitudinal: A Machine Learning Library for Longitudinal Classification in Python

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DOI: 10.xxxxxx/draft

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Submitted: 09 May 2025
Published: unpublished

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Introduction

Longitudinal data, characterised by repeated measurements of variables over time, presents unique challenges and opportunities in machine learning. This paper introduces `Scikit-Longitudinal`, a Python library designed to address these challenges by providing a comprehensive set of tools for longitudinal data classification. Built to integrate with the popular `Scikit-Learn` library, `Scikit-Longitudinal` offers a robust solution for researchers and practitioners working with longitudinal datasets.

Summary

`Scikit-Longitudinal` is an open-source Python library that enhances machine learning for longitudinal data classification and integrates with the `Scikit-Learn` environment (Pedregosa et al., 2011).

Longitudinal data, which consists of repeated measurements of variables across time points (referred to as waves (Ribeiro & Freitas, 2019)), is extensively utilised in fields such as medicine, and social sciences. Unlike standard tabular datasets, it contains temporal relationships that necessitate specialised processing (Kelloway & Francis, 2012).

`Scikit-Longitudinal` addresses this with a novel library that includes:

- **Data Preparation**: Utilities such as `LongitudinalDataset` for loading and structuring data, defining temporal feature groups, and other techniques.
- **Data Transformation**: Methods to treat the temporal aspect of tabular data, by either (1) flattening the data into a static representation (i.e. ignoring time indices) for standard machine learning to be performed (e.g., `MarWavTimeMinus`, or `SepWav`), or (2) keeping the temporal structure (e.g., `MerWavTimePlus`), yet saving it for later use in longitudinal-data-aware `preprocessing` or `estimators` steps (Ribeiro & Freitas, 2019).
- **Preprocessing**: Longitudinal-data-aware feature selection primitives, such as `CFS-Per-Group` (Pomsuwan & Freitas, 2017), utilising the temporal information in the data to proceed with feature selection techniques (see feature selection review in (Theng & Bhoyar, 2024)).
- **Estimators**: Longitudinal-data-aware classifiers (Kotsiantis et al., 2007) (Ribeiro & Freitas, 2019), such as `LexicoRandomForestClassifier` (Ribeiro & Freitas, 2024), `LexicoGradientBoostingClassifier`, and `NestedTreesClassifier` (Ovchinnik et al., 2022), which leverage the temporal structure of the data to ideally enhance classification performance.

In total, the library implements 1 data preparation method, 4 data transformation methods, 1 preprocessing method, and 6 estimators, 2 of which have been published as stand

alone methods in the literature (the above named `LexicoRandomForestClassifier` and `NestedTreesClassifier` methods).

`Scikit-Longitudinal` emphasises highly-typed, Pythonic code, with substantial test coverage (over 88%) and comprehensive documentation (over 72%).

Finally, `Scikit-Longitudinal` can also be abbreviated `Sklong`, and is available on PyPI. Feel free to explore the official documentation for various installation methods.

Longitudinal Classification

Longitudinal classification is a variant of the standard classification task where the data includes features taking values at multiple time points / "waves" (Ribeiro & Freitas, 2019), e.g., cholesterol values measured at different waves. Longitudinal classification is particularly relevant in biomedical applications, since biomedical data about patients is often collected across long time periods.

The challenge is to learn a model that predicts the class label (Y) for an instance while accounting for the evolution of features' values over time, i.e., to learn a predictive model (classifier function) of the form:

$$Y \leftarrow f(X_{1,1}, X_{1,2}, \dots, X_{1,T}, \dots, X_{K,1}, X_{K,2}, \dots, X_{K,T})$$

where $X_{i,j}$, for $i = 1, \dots, K$ and $j = 1, \dots, T$, is the value of the i-th feature at the j-th wave (time point), K is the number of features, and T is the number of waves. The classifier function $f(\cdot)$ can either operate on a transformed version of the data where temporal information is "flattened", allowing the application of standard machine learning algorithms, or handle the temporal dependencies between a feature's values across time and between different features directly. Note that, in the type of longitudinal classification task for which `Sklong` was designed, the features are longitudinal, but the class variable is not; i.e., the goal is to predict the class label of an instance at a single time point (usually the last wave).

There are two broad approaches for coping with longitudinal data (Ribeiro & Freitas, 2019): (1) **Data Transformation**: this approach involves preprocessing methods that convert longitudinal data into a standard, "flattened" non-longitudinal format. This transformation enables the use of any standard, non-longitudinal classification algorithm on the data. However, this approach may result in the loss of relevant information regarding how a feature's values change over time. (2) **Algorithm Adaptation**: this approach entails modifying classification algorithms to directly handle temporal dependencies inherent in longitudinal datasets. This preserves the temporal dynamics of the data but may require more complex tooling.

Statement of Need

To the best of our knowledge, no package in the `Scikit-learn` ecosystem provides an easy solution for longitudinal classification. Standard Python libraries, such as `Scikit-learn` itself, lack support for longitudinal data, leading to inefficient and inaccurate analysis. `R` includes statistical packages for longitudinal data (e.g., `nlme` (Pinheiro & Bates, 2000), `GPBoost` (Sigrist, 2022)). However, they often are not suitable for machine learning workflows often created in Python. On the other hand, systems such as Auto-Prognosis (Alaa & Schaar, 2018) focusses on longitudinal classification, but lack the simplicity of `Scikit-learn` and convenience of use out of the box that these systems are often lacking.

Given the lack of Python libraries, integration with the popular `Scikit-Learn` API, and the absence of out-of-the-box solutions for longitudinal classification, there is a clear need for a library that provides tools for longitudinal data preparation, transformation, preprocessing, and estimation (model learning).

Limitations and Future Work

At present, `Scikit-Longitudinal` primarily focuses on the classification task and does not yet include support for regression or neural networks. Future development could expand the library in these directions.

Acknowledgements

We thank the authors and contributors of `Scikit-learn` for their pioneering work in machine learning. We thank the NeuroData team for their contributions to `Scikit-Tree` (Li et al., 2024), which enables modification of `Scikit-learn`'s Cython trees for optimisation performance. We are grateful to the researchers who contributed to the design of many primitives within `Scikit-Longitudinal`, including Dr. Tossapol Pomsuwan (Pomsuwan, 2018; Pomsuwan & Freitas, 2017), Dr. Sergey Ovchinnik & Dr. Fernando Otero (Ovchinnik et al., 2022), and Dr. Caio Ribeiro (Ribeiro, 2022; Ribeiro & Freitas, 2019, 2024).

This work was completed during a PhD project (Provost & Freitas, 2024) at the University of Kent.

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